Himaayah Schools
ACADEMY

GUIDE

وَقُولُوا لِلنَّاسِ حُسْنًا

"And speak to people good words." (al-Baqarah 2:83)

JAMB Use of English

A UTME study guide: comprehension, lexis and structure, the sounds of English, the set text, worked examples and a practice test.

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمٰنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Before you begin

Use of English is the one paper every UTME candidate sits, and it carries 60 of the 180 questions. It tests reading, vocabulary, grammar and spoken English, and it rewards steady daily practice more than last-minute cramming. This guide gives you the syllabus, the rules and sounds you must know, worked examples of every question type, the traps our mentors see most often, an 8-week plan and a practice test.

The UTME at a glance	
Subjects	Use of English is compulsory for every candidate, with three other subjects for your course. It has 60 questions; each other subject has 40.
Questions	Use of English 60; each other subject 40; 180 questions in all, on computer (CBT).
Time	About two hours for all four papers, so roughly 40 seconds a question. You move freely between subjects.
Marking	Each subject is scored out of 100, for a total out of 400. There is no negative marking: never leave a question blank.

Check the official details

Exam rules and syllabuses can change from year to year. Always check the current JAMB brochure and the official Use of English syllabus on the JAMB website or e-facility portal, and follow them where they differ from this guide.

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Part 1 The syllabus at a glance

Study from the **JAMB syllabus**, not only from your school notes: every UTME question comes from a topic on it. The topics fall into these areas:

Area	Topics
Comprehension and summary	Reading passages with questions on meaning, the writer's attitude, inference and vocabulary in context; a cloze passage with gaps to fill; summary questions
Lexis and structure	Synonyms and antonyms; words and phrases nearest or opposite in meaning; sentence completion; grammar: concord, tenses, pronouns, prepositions, question tags; idioms and phrasal verbs; spelling
Oral forms	Vowels and diphthongs; consonants and consonant clusters; words with the same sound; rhymes; word stress; emphatic stress and intonation
The recommended text	Questions on the set novel named in the current JAMB brochure. The text changes every few years, so check the brochure for your exam year and read the book itself, not a summary only

Lexis and structure, together with comprehension, make up most of the paper. The set-text questions are the easiest marks to secure if you have read the book well.

Part 2 Rules, sounds and words

Concord: the rules that come every year

Rule	Example
Two subjects joined by “and” take a plural verb	Musa and Ada **are** here.
“Either… or”, “neither… nor”: the verb agrees with the nearer subject	Neither the teacher nor the students **were** late. / Neither the students nor the teacher **was** late.
“Each”, “every”, “everyone”, “nobody”, “one of…” take a singular verb	Each of the boys **has** a book. One of the girls **is** absent.
“As well as”, “together with”, “along with” do not change the subject	The principal, as well as the teachers, **is** coming.
Collective nouns: singular as a unit, plural as individuals	The jury **has** reached a verdict. / The jury **are** arguing among themselves.
Some nouns are always plural or always singular	The scissors **are**… / The news **is**… / Mathematics **is**…
“The number of” is singular; “a number of” is plural	The number of candidates **is** rising. A number of candidates **are** absent.

Question tags and tense

Rule	Example
Positive statement, negative tag; negative statement, positive tag	She is ready, **isn’t she?** / He can’t swim, **can he?**
Special tags	Let’s go, **shall we?** / I am late, **aren’t I?** / Nobody came, **did they?**
Sequence of tenses: a past main verb takes past in the reported clause	He said that he **was** tired (not “is”).
“If” clauses	If I **had** known, I **would have** come. / If I **were** you, I would apologise.

The vowels of English

Sound	As in	Sound	As in
/iː/	seat, key, people	/ʊ/	put, book, woman
/ɪ/	sit, women, busy	/uː/	food, blue, shoe
/e/	set, bread, said	/ʌ/	cup, blood, love
/æ/	sat, plait	/ɜː/	bird, word, learn
/ɑː/	cart, heart, calm	/ə/	about, mother (unstressed)
/ɒ/	cot, want, knowledge	/ɔː/	caught, door, saw

Diphthongs and tricky consonants

Sound	As in	Sound	As in
/eɪ/	day, great, eight	/aʊ/	now, house, bough
/aɪ/	my, height, buy	/ɪə/	here, beer, fierce
/ɔɪ/	boy, oil	/eə/	hair, there, bear
/əʊ/	go, though, sew	/ʊə/	poor, tour, sure
/θ/	think, thought	/ð/	this, though, bathe
/ʃ/	ship, nation, sugar	/ʒ/	measure, vision, beige
/tʃ/	church, nature	/dʒ/	judge, gem, soldier

Words people confuse

Word	Meaning	Word	Meaning
affect (verb)	to influence	effect (noun)	a result
principal	chief; head of school	principle	a rule or belief
stationary	not moving	stationery	paper, pens
complement	completes	compliment	praise
council	a body of people	counsel	advice
lose	to misplace	loose	not tight
eminent	famous	imminent	about to happen
elicit	to draw out	illicit	unlawful

Word stress often changes with the part of speech: a ˈrecord (noun), to reˈcord (verb); an ˈimport, to imˈport; a ˈpresent, to preˈsent. Words ending in -tion and -ic usually stress the syllable before: eduˈcation, ecoˈnomic.

Part 3 Every question type, explained

Example 1. Choose the option that best completes the sentence: “Neither the coach nor the players ___ satisfied with the result.”

→ With “neither… nor”, the verb agrees with the nearer subject.

→ “Players” is plural, so the verb is plural.

Answer: were

Example 2. Choose the word nearest in meaning to the underlined word: “The witness gave a lucid account of the accident.”

→ Lucid means clear and easy to understand.

→ Options like “long” or “strange” do not fit the meaning.

Answer: clear

Example 3. Choose the word opposite in meaning to the underlined word: “Her uncle is very frugal with money.”

→ Frugal means careful and sparing.

→ The opposite is wasteful.

Answer: extravagant

Example 4. Choose the correct question tag: “Let’s start the meeting, ___?”

→ “Let’s” always takes “shall we?”

Answer: shall we?

Example 5. Choose the word that has the same vowel sound as the one in “cup”.

→ “Cup” has /ʌ/.

→ “Blood” is pronounced /blʌd/, with the same vowel; “boot” and “cook” have different vowels.

Answer: blood

Example 6. Which syllable carries the main stress in “photography”?

→ Words ending in -graphy stress the syllable before -graphy: pho-TO-gra-phy.

Answer: The second syllable

Example 7. Choose the meaning of the idiom: “After years of quarrelling, the two families decided to bury the hatchet.”

→ To bury the hatchet is to end a quarrel and make peace.

Answer: They made peace

Example 8. Choose the correctly spelt word.

→ Common traps: accommodate (double c, double m), embarrass (double r, double s), occurrence, separate, privilege.

Answer: accommodate

Example 9. Comprehension: "The writer's attitude to the new policy is best described as..."
→ Look for the writer's words of judgement: "sadly", "at last", "so-called".
→ Choose the option the whole passage supports, not just one sentence.
Answer: the option supported by the writer's own words in the passage

Part 4 Traps that cost marks

Trap	What to do
Choosing the answer that "sounds right"	Apply the rule. Many wrong options sound natural in everyday speech.
Reading the passage last	Read the questions first, then the passage, so you read with purpose.
Picking a synonym out of context	The meaning must fit the sentence. Replace the word with your choice and read it again.
Judging sounds by spelling	English spelling misleads: "women" has /ɪ/, "blood" has /ʌ/. Learn sounds from a dictionary or teacher.
Skipping the set text	Read the recommended novel at least twice. Those questions are among the easiest marks.
Spending too long on one passage	Keep to about 40 seconds a question. Flag hard ones and return.
Not reading "nearest", "opposite", "odd one out"	Underline the instruction word before you choose.

Part 5 An 8-week plan

Start at least eight weeks before the exam. Each week: learn the topics, make short notes and solve past questions under time. Keep one day a week for revision.

Week	Focus	Practice
1	Concord, tenses and question tags	20 questions a day; note every mistake
2	Vowels and diphthongs	Say each sound aloud; 15 oral questions a day
3	Consonants, stress and intonation	Oral past questions; record yourself
4	Vocabulary: synonyms and antonyms	Learn 15 new words a day; review them
5	Comprehension and cloze	Two passages a day, timed
6	The recommended text: first full reading	Notes on plot, characters, themes
7	The recommended text again, and idioms	Set-text and idiom past questions
8	Full revision and mock exams	Two full timed papers; review all errors

Exam-day reminders

Read every option before choosing. Eliminate the clearly wrong ones first.

Do not spend more than a minute on one question: flag it and come back.

Answer every question; there is no penalty for a wrong answer.

Check that your answers are saved before you submit, and keep an eye on the clock for all four subjects.

Test Practice test

Give yourself 10 minutes for these 15 questions, as in the real exam. The answers follow.

1. **Choose the correct option: “Each of the students ___ a laptop.”**
   a) have b) has c) are having d) were having

2. **“The principal, together with his deputies, ___ arrived.”**
   a) have b) are c) has d) were

3. **Choose the correct tag: “She hardly ever comes late, ___?”**
   a) does she b) doesn’t she c) isn’t it d) is she

4. **Choose the word nearest in meaning to “meticulous”.**
   a) Careless b) Careful c) Quick d) Proud

5. **Choose the word opposite in meaning to “benevolent”.**
   a) Kind b) Generous c) Wise d) Malevolent

6. **Which word has the same vowel as “seat”?**
   a) People b) Sit c) Set d) Sat

7. **Which word has the sound /ʒ/?**
   a) Ship b) Measure c) Judge d) Church

8. **In “to present” (verb), the stress falls on:**
   a) The first syllable b) The second syllable c) Both d) Neither

9. **“If I ___ you, I would accept the offer.”**
   a) am b) was c) were d) be

10. **“He said that he ___ tired.”**
    a) is b) was c) has been d) be

11. **Choose the correctly spelt word.**
    a) Embarass b) Embarrass c) Embaras d) Emmbarrass

12. **“To let the cat out of the bag” means to:**
    a) Free an animal b) Reveal a secret c) Start a quarrel d) Go shopping

13. **“The jury ___ divided in their opinions.”**
    a) is b) was c) were d) has

14. **Choose the odd one out by its vowel sound.**
    a) Bird b) Word c) Heard d) Beard

15. **“The news ___ good today.”**
    a) are b) is c) were d) have been

No.	Answer	No.	Answer
1	b) has	9	c) were
2	c) has	10	b) was
3	a) does she	11	b) Embarrass
4	b) Careful	12	b) Reveal a secret
5	d) Malevolent	13	c) were
6	a) People	14	d) Beard
7	b) Measure	15	b) is
8	b) Second syllable		

Recommended textbooks

- **Comprehensive English Language for Senior Secondary Schools**, or the English textbook your school uses.
- **Exam Focus: Use of English for WASSCE and UTME**.
- **An English Pronouncing Dictionary** or a good learner's dictionary with sound symbols.
- The **recommended novel** named in the current JAMB brochure.
- **Past questions**: solve at least the last ten years' UTME Use of English questions, timing yourself, and study every one you get wrong.

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وَمَا تَوْفِيقِي إِلَّا بِاللَّهِ

"And my success is only through Allah." (Hūd 11:88)

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Sixty questions, every candidate.

This guide from the Himaayah Academy helps every UTME candidate prepare for the one paper they all sit, with the rules, the sounds and the practice that raise scores.

- The Use of English syllabus in four areas
- Concord, tenses and question tags
- The vowels, diphthongs and consonants of English
- Every question type, explained
- An 8-week plan and a 15-question practice test

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Live UTME classes with a personal mentor, daily tasks, weekly mock exams and CBT practice, all online.

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